

require to be a freelance writer is the ability to unearth, comprehend, digest and effectively elucidate vast amounts of information in relatively short amounts of time.

- **Slick sales skillz:** In the worst case scenario, you know nothing about anything worth knowing, in which case, you can start here. The other facet of being paid to craft combinations of words, in its purest form, is called copywriting. When online, it is the world of well integrated SEO/SMO, optimizing the CTR with compelling CTAs, and all manner of herding the public towards business goals. (If you don't know what the acronyms stand for, time to put the previous point to practice.) Under the hood and offline, this is advertising, marketing, psychology, persuasion. What we are getting to is summed up in the following platitude - is not just what you say, but how you say it. The latter is crucial for effectively using the former. When becoming a freelance writer, you will blend wordsmithing with marketing. Like a UX designer, you are at the intersection of user goals and business goals, so you have to get good at knowing what people want. The second salient skill you need to be a freelance writer is the ability to create engagement while getting to the point.

Types of the trade

Although we have been throwing the term 'freelance writer' around like it means one thing, there are nuances worth knowing. Just as there's more than one type of doctor, there's many types of freelance writer. The following taxonomy is in no way definitive but at least indicative-

1. The most common breed of freelance writers is the content writer. This species can be found on the web or in print ecosystems, and feeds on a variety of prey. This behaviour is sometimes referred to as 'catering to the crowd'. The work of content writers can span many domains but often has a conversational tone and exists primarily to create engagement. Subspecies of the content writer include creative writers, bloggers, SEO writers, and social media managers.
2. A related species of writers is the business writer. While they feed on similar prey as the content writer, the business writer is more selective and has more sophisticated hunting behaviours. These evolved hunting tools include white papers, proposals, pamphlets, reports, targeted copy, etc. Subspecies of the business writer are B2B writers, copy writers, business consultants, lead generators, propaganda creators (considering politics a subset of business).